

Australia: Consumer Sentiment: Sentiment Very Weak for Third Consecutive Month

Bottom line: Australian consumer sentiment decreased 2.9%mom in June to 80.6, around 20% below its historical average (100.1). The perceptions of family finances sub-components deteriorated in the month, as did perceptions of long-term economic conditions. The perceptions of year-ahead economic conditions sub-component rose, but remains at very weak levels. This is the third consecutive month of very weak surveyed sentiment, though we note that the RBA find limited evidence of sentiment being an independent driver of consumption.

Sentiment towards the housing market remained weak. House price expectations fell 14.9%mom to below its long-run average for the first time in three years.

Main points:

- **Australian consumer sentiment** decreased 2.9%mom in June to 80.6, around 20% below its historical average (100.1). This is the third consecutive month of very weak surveyed sentiment. However, we note the RBA have stated that “past research had found only limited evidence of sentiment being an independent driver of consumption,” though “large changes in sentiment might have more significant implications if they persist”.
- **Compositionally**, perceptions of family finances deteriorated with the current (-7.5%mom) and year-ahead measure (-8.5%mom) both falling. Long-term perceptions of economic conditions also fell (-3.2%mom), though year-ahead expectations improved from low levels (+4.9%mom). The ‘time to buy a major household item’ rose (+0.9%mom). Unemployment expectations were little changed (-0.1%mom).
- **Sentiment towards housing remained weak.** House price expectations fell 14.9%mom to below its long-run average for the first time in three years. By state, the falls were largest in Sydney (-19%mom) and Melbourne (-18%mom), where actual house prices have been falling. The ‘time to buy a dwelling’ index rebounded 12.6%mom in the month following a sharp drop in May. Mortgage rate expectations also eased (-4.8%mom).

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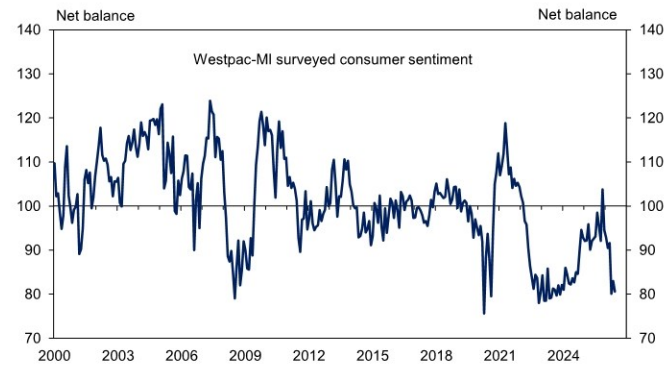
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Exhibit 1: Consumer sentiment fell in June reversing the small rise in May



Source: Haver Analytics, Goldman Sachs Global Investment Research

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